

Anoplopoma fimbria

Sablefish



Length Up to 3½ ft (1.1 m)
Weight Up to 125 lb (57 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location North Pacific



Although it is placed in the same order as the scorpionfish, the sablefish belongs to a different family that contains only 2 species. The sablefish is a widespread, North Pacific fish that looks superficially like a cod (see pp.510), with its long, streamlined body and widely spaced fins. Adults are blackish to greenish gray above, often with blotches or stripes, and have a white underside; juveniles are blue-black above. Young fishes live near the ocean surface, usually near coasts, where they feed on zooplankton. In contrast, the adults live close to the seabed. The sablefish makes extensive migrations along coasts, moving to deeper water in winter. It is an ambush predator that cruises in groups, chasing prey. It feeds on crustaceans, worms, and small fishes, such as lanternfishes. An important food source, caught in trawls and traps, and on long lines, the sablefish is commercially exploited and widely marketed, mostly in Asia.

Synanceia verrucosa

Stonefish



Length Up to 23½ in (60 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

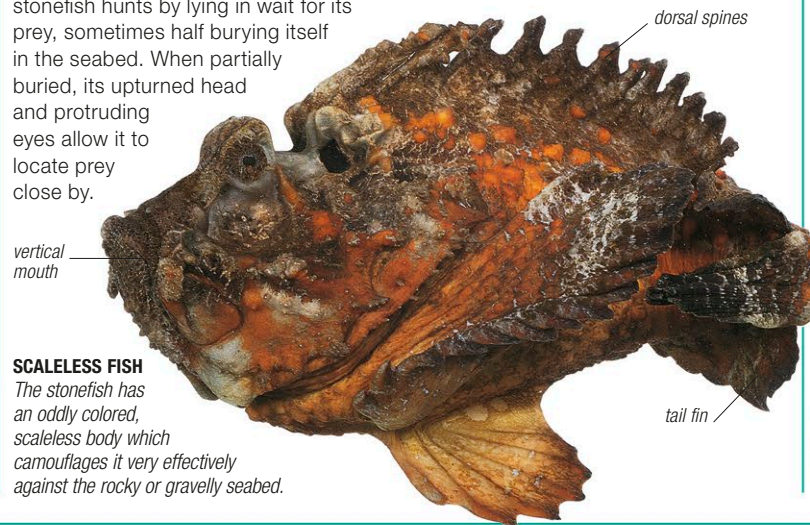
Location Indo-Pacific



This fish is a stout, slow-moving predator, with superb camouflage and deadly venom produced by glands at the base of its 13 dorsal spines. The spines are equipped with sharp tips, and these can easily penetrate human skin, sometimes with fatal results. The stonefish hunts by lying in wait for its prey, sometimes half burying itself in the seabed. When partially buried, its upturned head and protruding eyes allow it to locate prey close by.

SCALELESS FISH

The stonefish has an oddly colored, scaleless body which camouflages it very effectively against the rocky or gravelly seabed.



HIDDEN DANGER



Making the most of its cryptic coloring, the stonefish makes itself even less conspicuous by scooping out a shallow depression on the seabed with its pectoral fins. It then piles up sand or mud around its body, and waits for prey.

Scorpaena porcus

Black scorpionfish



Length Up to 16 in (40 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Black Sea



The black scorpionfish, or rascasse, has a large, bulbous head with large eyes and mouth, a brown body with mottled markings, and several mosslike appendages between its mouth and eyes. It is a sit-and-wait predator that lurks among weed-covered rocks, using its highly effective camouflage to avoid being seen. All of its fins have rounded margins, and the spines of its dorsal, pelvic, and anal fins have poison glands, which, when erect, can inflict a harmful sting on its predators.

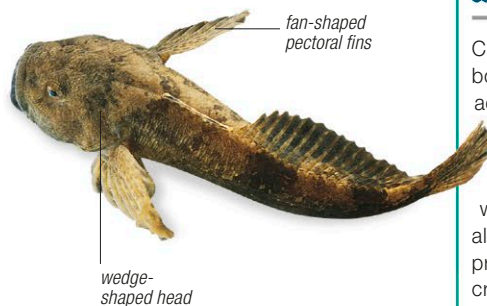
*Cottus gobio*

Bullhead



Length Up to 7 in (18 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location W. Europe



The bullhead is a solitary freshwater species that lives under stones or in dense aquatic vegetation, where its dark brown, marbled skin provides excellent camouflage. It feeds on small, bottom invertebrates, such as insect larvae. Spawning occurs between March and May, depending on the locality. The male excavates a small depression under a stone for the female to lay her eggs, and guards the eggs until they hatch.

Chelidonichthys lucerna

Tub gurnard



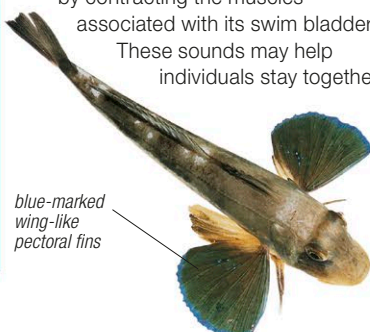
Length Up to 30 in (75 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Black Sea



Colored brown to reddish, with a bony-plated head, the tub gurnard has adapted to life on the seabed. It has 3 isolated, long, and highly mobile rays on each of its pectoral fins that act as legs live in shallow water with strong waves. These fin rays are also highly sensitive and are used to probe the seabed for mollusks and crustaceans, which, along with fishes, form its main diet. The tub gurnard is capable of producing grunting sounds by contracting the muscles associated with its swim bladder.

These sounds may help individuals stay together.

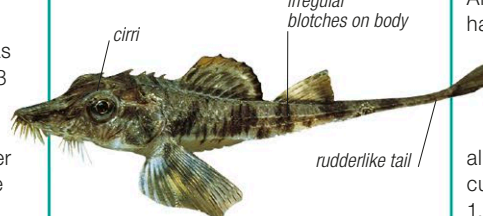
*Agonus acipenserinus*

Sturgeon poacher



Length Up to 12 in (31 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location North Pacific



The sturgeon poacher is one of about 50 species of poacher, and derives its name, from its sturgeonlike shape. Like all poachers, it has a large head and elongated snout, and uses its pectoral fins like oars and its tail like a rudder to move along the seabed. All poachers also have a distinctive cluster of finely divided barbels, called cirri, that hang from their downward-pointing mouths. The taste buds on the cirri are used to probe the seabed for crustaceans and small animals. Slow-moving poachers are protected by bony plates.

Cyclopterus lumpus

Lumpsucker

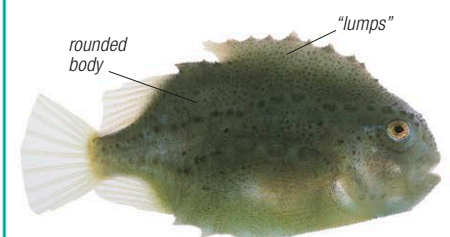


Length Up to 23½ in (60 cm)
Weight Up to 21 lb (9.5 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location North Atlantic



Also called the lumpfish, this stout fish has an adhesive disk, formed from modified pelvic fins, on its underside. This acts as a sucker and anchors the slow-moving lumpsucker to rocks and seaweed, allowing it to live in places where the current is strong. Found in water up to 1,000 ft (300 m) deep, it swims into much shallower waters to breed.



ARMOR PLATING

Lumpsuckers get their characteristic knobby shape from bony plates scattered over the body. Arranged in rows, these run along the fish's back and sides.